devilishly charming deceiver, the master of flattery and treachery, who corrupted the nobles of Kabul. ‘On the outside he seems a man, but inside he is the very devil,’ one nobleman tells Dost Mohammad.[14] Likewise to Afghan eyes the western armies were remarkable for their heartlessness, for their lack of any of the basic values of chivalry and especially for their indifference to civilian casualties. ‘From their rancour and spite there will be burning houses and blazing walls,’ Dost Mohammad warns Akbar Khan in the *Akbarnama*.

> For such is how they show their strength
> Terrorising those who dare to resist them
>
> As is their custom, they will subjugate the people
> So that no one makes a claim to equality[15]

It is, moreover, a consistent complaint in the Afghan sources that the British had no respect for women, raping and dishonouring wherever they went, and riding ‘the steed of their lust unbridled day and night’. The British, in other words, are depicted in the Afghan sources as treacherous and oppressive women-abusing terrorists. This is not the way we expect Afghans to look at us.

At the centre of all the Afghan sources is the enigmatic figure of Shah Shuja himself. Shuja emerges through his own writings and those of his supporters as a sophisticated and highly intelligent man who models himself on the Timurid monarchs of the past. The self-portrait in the *Waqi’at* is backed by that of other writers to reveal a resolute, brave and unbreakable figure, weathering all that fate can throw at him. It is a portrait startlingly different to the corrupt and incompetent figure dismissed by the conceited British administrators who first reinstalled then tried to marginalise the heir to the Durrani Empire. He is also a very different figure to the weak quisling demonised in modern Afghanistan after 170 years of Barakzai propaganda. Shuja created around him a highly cultured Persianate world – there is no indication that the Shah ever knew Pashtu, and he certainly did not write in it. He lived, as the Mughals did before him, a life of mobile kingship and in many ways he emerges as the last Timurid, exercising his rule in a country that was still at the crossroads of Iran, Central Asia, China and Hindustan, not the mountainous periphery it would later become.